

MARCUS AURELIUS · 121-180 CE — WRITTEN C. 170-180, IN GREEK — NEVER INTENDED TO BE READ

Meditations

Twelve books of notes a Roman emperor wrote to himself, mostly on campaign, arguing with his own worst impulses.

There is no other book like this, and the reason is structural rather than literary: it is the private working notebook of the most powerful man on earth, and he is not explaining anything to anyone. **He is telling himself, over and over, the same handful of things — because he keeps failing to remember them.** The consolation most readers take from it is not that Marcus had answers, but that a man with absolute power, the best education available, and thirty years of practice was still struggling with irritation, procrastination, self-importance and the fear of death.

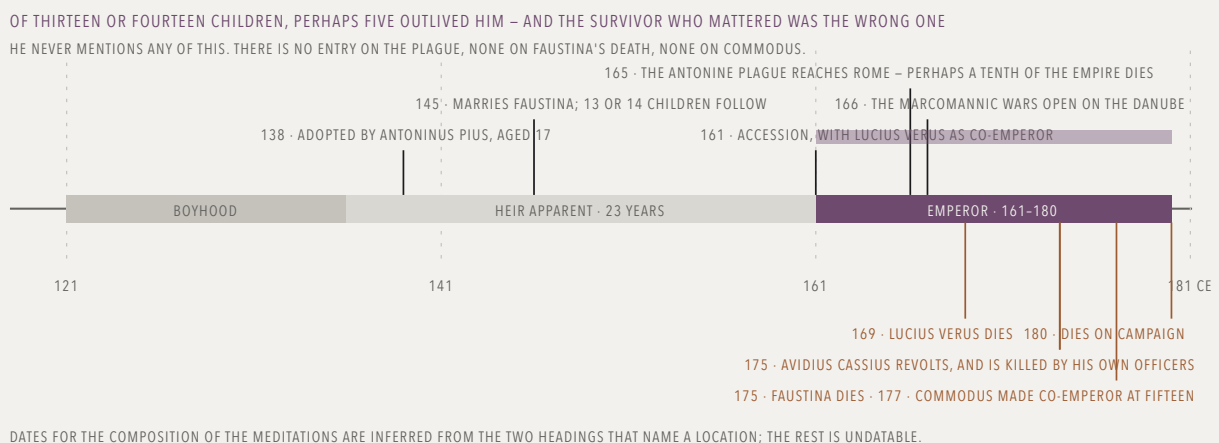
BOOKS	LENGTH	WRITTEN	ORIGINAL TITLE
12 FRAGMENTS, NOT CHAPTERS	≈35,000 words A SHORT EVENING	on campaign THE DANUBE FRONTIER	<i>Tà eis heautón</i> "TO HIMSELF"

Marcus Annius Verus was born in Rome in 121 into a wealthy senatorial family of Spanish origin. His father died when he was small and he was raised by his grandfather and mother. The emperor Hadrian noticed him young and nicknamed him *Verissimus* — "most truthful," a pun on the family name — and in 138, needing to secure the succession two generations deep, arranged for Antoninus Pius to adopt both Marcus and Lucius Verus. **Marcus was seventeen and had just been handed the empire, on a twenty-three-year delay.**

Those twenty-three years as heir apparent are the least discussed and probably most formative part of his life. He served as consul, sat in the Senate, watched Antoninus govern, and — as Book 1 records at length — studied him. He also studied philosophy intensely enough that his rhetoric tutor Fronto wrote to him complaining about it. A substantial correspondence with Fronto survives and is worth knowing about, because it shows a completely different Marcus: chatty, affectionate, anxious about his health, gossiping about grape harvests. Whoever wrote the *Meditations* also wrote letters about a sore throat.

He became emperor in 161 and immediately did something no Roman had done: he insisted the Senate confirm Lucius Verus as his equal co-emperor, on the grounds that Hadrian had intended both. It was the first joint principate in Roman history and it worked, more or less, until Verus died in 169. What followed was nineteen years in which almost everything went wrong at once — a war in the east, a pandemic brought home by the returning army, a permanent crisis on the Danube, the revolt of his most trusted general, and the deaths of his wife and most of his children.

PLATE 01 FIFTY-NINE YEARS, AND WHAT FILLED THEM



Set the black line against the red one. Almost every event a biographer would call decisive falls in the last fifteen years, and the notebook that overlaps them exactly is silent about all of it. Whatever Marcus was using the writing for, it was not processing events.

The first book is unlike the other eleven and is, for my money, the most quietly extraordinary thing in the whole text. It is a list. Marcus goes through the people who formed him — grandfather, parents, tutors, philosophers, his adoptive father, and finally the gods — and for each one names the specific quality he took from them. **No self-praise, no narrative, no complaints: just an audit of where his character came from, itemised.**

The entries get more precise as they go, and they are frequently unglamorous. From his tutor: not to take sides at the races, and to do his own work. From Alexander the grammarian: not to correct people's grammar in public, but to work the right expression into your reply. From Alexander the Platonist: not to say "I'm too busy" more often than necessary, or use it to dodge obligations. From Fronto, of all people, he says he learned what envy and duplicity look like in a ruler. From Diognetus he got scepticism about miracle-workers and charmers, and the habit of sleeping on a plain board.

The philosophical debts are the ones with consequences. Rusticus told him his character needed work, steered him away from writing poetry and showy rhetoric, taught him to read carefully rather than be satisfied with a general sense — and lent him his own copy of the *Discourses* of Epictetus. Almost everything in the remaining eleven books descends from that loan. Apollonius gave him independence and steadiness under pain and loss. Sextus gave him the model of a household run without anger.

PLATE 02 THE SEVENTEEN DEBTS, AND WHAT EACH ONE SUPPLIED

1.1 – 1.17	WHAT HE SAYS HE TOOK FROM THEM
VERUS, GRANDFATHER	CHARACTER, AND CONTROL OF HIS TEMPER
HIS FATHER, BY REPUTE	MODESTY; A MASCULINE RETICENCE
DOMITIA LUCILLA, MOTHER	PIETY, GENEROSITY, PLAIN LIVING – "FAR REMOVED FROM THE WAY OF THE RICH"
GREAT-GRANDFATHER	PRIVATE TUTORS AT HOME, AND TO SPEND MONEY ON THAT WITHOUT HESITATING
HIS TUTOR	NOT TO BACK THE GREENS OR THE BLUES; ENDURANCE; TO DO HIS OWN WORK
DIOGNETUS	NOT TO BE TAKEN IN BY CONJURERS AND CHARLATANS; TO WRITE DIALOGUES YOUNG
RUSTICUS	THAT HIS CHARACTER NEEDED WORK; TO READ CLOSELY; AND EPICTETUS'S DISCOURSES
APOLLONIUS	INDEPENDENCE; RELIANCE ON REASON ALONE; STEADINESS IN PAIN AND LOSS
SEXTUS	A HOUSEHOLD GOVERNED WITHOUT ANGER; LIVING IN ACCORD WITH NATURE
ALEXANDER THE GRAMMARIAN	NOT TO CORRECT PEOPLE'S GRAMMAR, BUT TO SUPPLY THE RIGHT WORD IN REPLY
FRONTO	WHAT ENVY, DUPLICITY AND HYPOCRISY LOOK LIKE IN A MAN WITH POWER
ALEXANDER THE PLATONIST	NOT TO SAY "I AM TOO BUSY" UNLESS IT IS TRUE AND UNAVOIDABLE
CATULUS	NOT TO SHRUG OFF A FRIEND'S COMPLAINT; TO BE STEADY TOWARD TEACHERS
SEVERUS	A STATE WITH ONE LAW FOR ALL, OF EQUAL RIGHTS AND FREE SPEECH
MAXIMUS	SELF-MASTERY; CHEERFULNESS; DIGNITY IN ILLNESS; NEVER IN A HURRY

TWO ENTRIES ARE MISSING HERE BECAUSE THEY NEED MORE ROOM THAN A LINE: 1.16 ON ANTONINUS PIUS, AND 1.17 ON THE GODS.

Notice how much of it is about restraint rather than achievement: not correcting people, not making excuses, not taking sides, not being impressed. Marcus is cataloguing an education in how to be less annoying and more reliable, which is not what one expects a Roman emperor to have valued.

THE TWO LONG ENTRIES

Antoninus Pius, his adoptive father, gets the longest section in the book by a wide margin, and it reads as a portrait of the kind of ruler Marcus intends to be. What he singles out is almost entirely temperamental rather than political: that Antoninus worked steadily and finished what he started; that he was unmoved by flattery; that he would listen to anyone who had something useful to contribute, even in opposition; that he looked after his body without fuss, "not as one in love with life, nor for appearance"; that he had few needs and could go without; that he never rushed and

never dithered; that he was the same in private as in public. Marcus ends by telling himself to behave, in every situation, as Antoninus would have behaved. The last entry, 1.17, is addressed to the gods and is a list of the things he did not have to suffer. That he had good grandparents, parents, sister, teachers and friends. That he never wronged any of them, though he had the temperament to. That he did not grow up too fast, and remained under his mother's roof. That when he wanted to help someone he was never told he lacked the means. That his children were neither stupid nor deformed. That he did not get further in rhetoric and poetry, which might have absorbed him. And — a line that has generated centuries of speculation given what Roman gossip said about her — that his wife was "so obedient, so affectionate, so unaffected."

A man in his fifties, on a frontier, in a plague, listing what has gone right. Book 1 is the only part of the *Meditations* that is not an argument with himself.

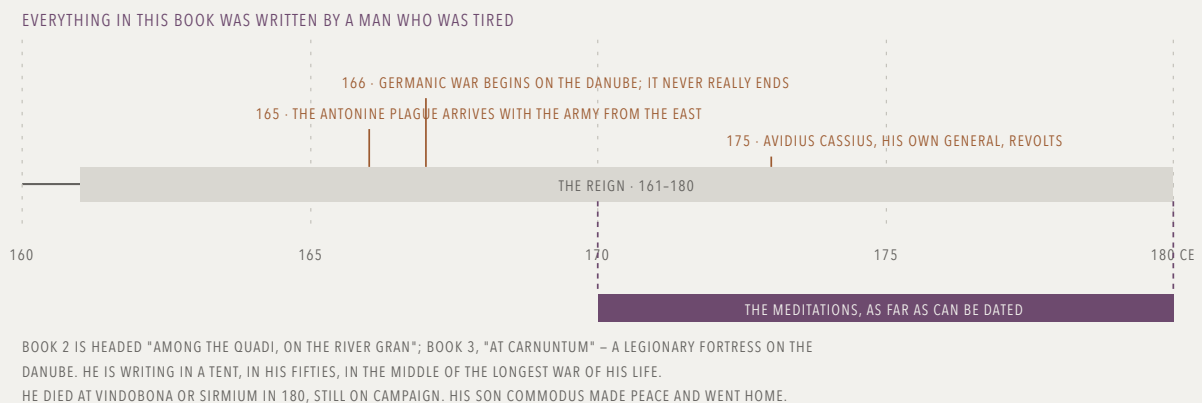
ON THE STRUCTURE OF THE OPENING BOOK

A Private Notebook That Should Not Exist

Who wrote it, when, and how improbable its survival was.

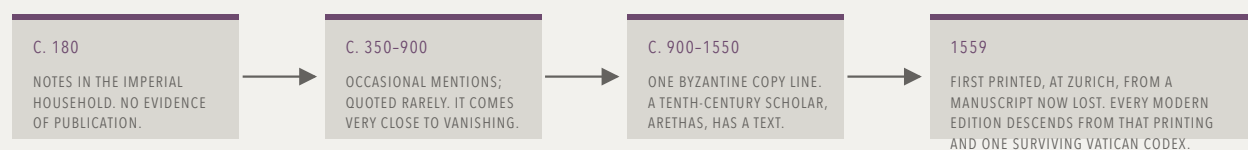
Marcus Aurelius ruled from 161 to 180, through a plague that may have killed a tenth of the empire, a decade of war on the Danube, and a revolt by his most trusted general. He wrote these notes in Greek — the language of philosophy, not of government — in camp, at night, for no reader. **The title we use is not his; the book has no argument, no structure, and no audience.** That is precisely what makes it useful.

PLATE 03 THE REIGN, AND WHERE THE WRITING HAPPENED



The circumstances matter for reading. These are not the reflections of a man in a garden with leisure to philosophise; they are notes written by someone managing a plague, a frontier war and a treasury, who used the practice as a way of getting through the next day.

PLATE 04 HOW A PRIVATE NOTEBOOK SURVIVED EIGHTEEN CENTURIES



THE UNCOMFORTABLE FACT

THE MOST WIDELY READ WORK OF ANCIENT PHILOSOPHY REACHED US THROUGH A SINGLE THIN THREAD, FROM A TEXT ITS AUTHOR NEVER MEANT ANYONE TO SEE. HAD THAT ONE LINE OF COPYING FAILED, WE WOULD KNOW MARCUS ONLY AS A COMPETENT EMPEROR WITH A DISASTROUS SON - AND WOULD HAVE NO IDEA WHAT HE WAS LIKE INSIDE.

Compare Livy, who wrote 142 books explicitly for publication and lost three-quarters of them. Transmission is close to random with respect to intent: what an author wanted preserved and what actually survived are two different lists.

BOOK 1 · "DEBTS AND LESSONS" – UNLIKE ANYTHING ELSE IN THE WORK

A LIST OF SEVENTEEN PEOPLE AND WHAT HE LEARNED FROM EACH. HIS GRANDFATHER: CHARACTER AND SELF-CONTROL. RUSTICUS: THE DISCOURSES OF EPICTETUS, AND TO STOP WRITING POETRY. ANTONINUS, HIS ADOPTIVE FATHER, GETS THE LONGEST ENTRY BY FAR.

BOOKS 2–12 · UNDIFFERENTIATED NOTES, NO ORDER, NO DEVELOPMENT

2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
QUADI	CARNUNTUM	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

ONLY BOOKS 2 AND 3 CARRY A LOCATION. THE REST ARE SIMPLY COLLECTIONS OF ENTRIES – SOME A SINGLE LINE, SOME A PAGE. THERE IS NO PROGRESSION: AN IDEA IN BOOK 12 IS OFTEN ONE ALREADY STATED IN BOOK 4, IN ALMOST THE SAME WORDS.

THE PRACTICAL CONSEQUENCE FOR A READER

YOU CANNOT READ THIS BOOK FOR ITS ARGUMENT, BECAUSE IT DOES NOT HAVE ONE. OPEN IT ANYWHERE; READ A FEW ENTRIES; STOP.

Book 1 is stylistically so different that many scholars think it was composed last, or separately. It is also the least quoted and, for some readers, the best thing in the book – a man in his fifties itemising exactly what he owes to each person who formed him.

The System He Is Drawing On

Marcus never explains Stoicism. He assumes it, and uses one corner of it.

The *Meditations* are the notes of a practitioner, not an introduction. Stoicism was already four centuries old and had a full physics, logic and ethics; Marcus uses almost none of the first two. **What he has taken, mostly through Epictetus, is a small set of practical operations he can run on himself when he is angry, frightened, or reluctant to get out of bed.**

PLATE 06 THE STOIC SYSTEM, AND THE PART MARCUS ACTUALLY USES

LOGIC

ARGUMENT, LANGUAGE, THE THEORY OF ASSENT AND OF WHAT COUNTS AS KNOWLEDGE.

MARCUS: ESSENTIALLY ABSENT

PHYSICS

THE COSMOS AS A SINGLE RATIONAL LIVING THING; FATE, PROVIDENCE, THE LOGOS.

MARCUS: ASSUMED, NOT ARGUED

ETHICS

WHAT IS UP TO ME; WHAT TO DESIRE; HOW TO ACT; HOW TO DEAL WITH OTHER PEOPLE AND DEATH.

MARCUS: ALMOST THE WHOLE BOOK

THE LINE HE STANDS AT THE END OF



The line at the bottom is worth noticing: a Cypriot merchant, a Greek logician, a Roman senator and playwright, a freed slave, and an emperor. Stoicism is the one ancient school with no social entry requirement, and Marcus takes it from a man who had been someone's property.

PLATE 07 THE ONE DISTINCTION EVERYTHING HANGS ON

UP TO ME

AND NOTHING ELSE IS

MY JUDGEMENT ABOUT WHAT HAPPENED

WHAT I CHOOSE TO PURSUE

WHAT I CHOOSE TO AVOID

WHETHER I ACT WELL RIGHT NOW

WHETHER I KEEP MY WORD

NOT UP TO ME

HOWEVER MUCH POWER I HOLD

MY BODY, MY HEALTH, MY DEATH

MY REPUTATION, NOW OR LATER

WHAT OTHER PEOPLE DO AND THINK

WHETHER THE PLAN WORKS

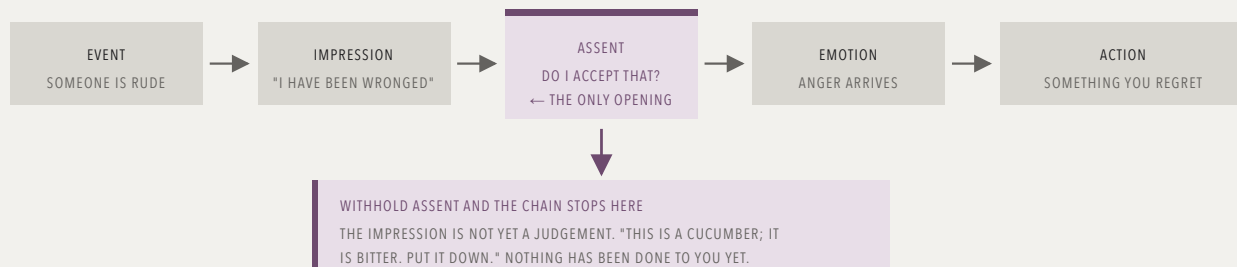
THE PLAGUE, THE DANUBE, THE SENATE

THE MOVE THAT MAKES IT MORE THAN A SLOGAN

DISTRESS DOES NOT COME FROM THE EVENT BUT FROM THE JUDGEMENT LAID ON TOP OF IT - AND THE JUDGEMENT SITS IN THE LEFT COLUMN. MARCUS, QUOTING THE SCHOOL: "TAKE AWAY THE OPINION, AND THE COMPLAINT IS TAKEN AWAY."

Note which side "whether the plan works" falls on. This is not a doctrine of passivity: you are obliged to act, and act well, and the obligation is unaffected by whether you will succeed. What you are released from is the requirement that the world cooperate.

PLATE 08 THE GAP BETWEEN IMPRESSION AND ACTION



MARCUS IS NOT CLAIMING THE IMPRESSION CAN BE PREVENTED – IT ARRIVES ON ITS OWN. HE IS CLAIMING THERE IS A MOMENT, BEFORE IT HARDENS INTO A JUDGEMENT, IN WHICH IT CAN BE EXAMINED AND REFUSED. ALMOST EVERY ENTRY IS AN ATTEMPT TO WIDEN THAT MOMENT.

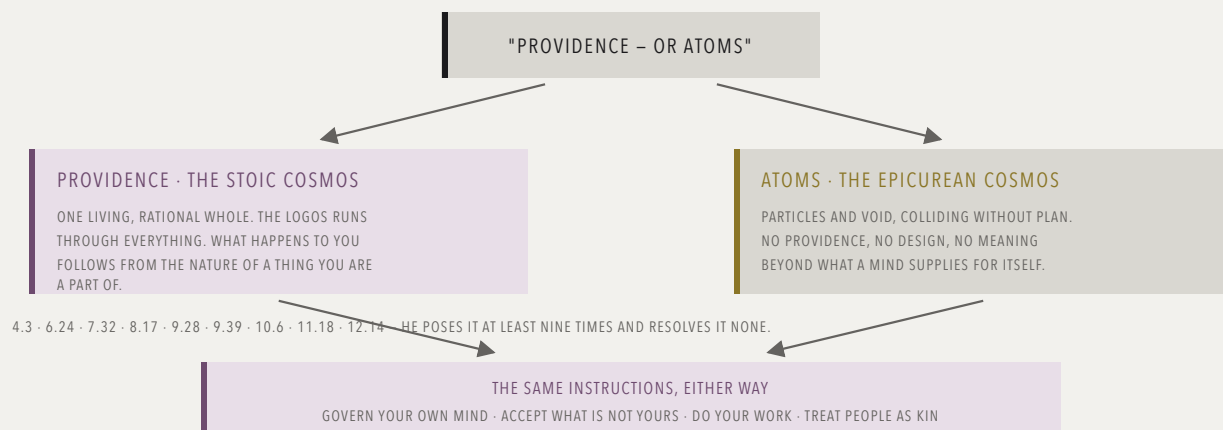
This is the operational core, and it is what modern cognitive therapy rediscovered independently in the 1950s – Albert Ellis credited the Stoics explicitly. The lineage is real, though the modern versions drop the cosmology that, for Marcus, made the whole thing make sense.

Orthodox Stoicism had a complete physics. The cosmos is a single living, rational being; everything that happens follows from its nature; the divine reason — the *logos* — pervades matter, and a human mind is a fragment of it. Fate is not a constraint imposed from outside but the unfolding of one thing you are part of. Accepting what happens is therefore not resignation but recognition.

Marcus holds this, mostly. What is remarkable, and what separates him from a textbook Stoic, is that he keeps raising the alternative and refusing to close it off. Again and again he sets out a disjunction: *either providence or atoms*. Either the universe is an ordered whole governed by reason, or it is Epicurean — a chance concourse of particles, with no plan, no providence and no meaning beyond what a mind makes. He states this at 4.3, at 6.24, at 7.32, at 8.17, at 9.28, at 9.39, at 10.6, at 11.18 and at 12.14, among others. He never decides.

What he does instead is more interesting than deciding would have been. He argues that his practical conclusions survive either answer. If there is providence, then what happens to you is part of an order that includes you, and complaint is incoherent. If there are only atoms, then nothing is owed to you by anything, no one is coming, and the only thing you have is your own mind — which is therefore all the more worth governing well. Either way: attend to your own conduct, accept what you cannot control, treat other people decently, and stop expecting the universe to explain itself. **The ethics are load-bearing; the metaphysics is scaffolding, and he knows it.**

PLATE 09 THE DISJUNCTION HE LEAVES OPEN



This is the feature that makes the book usable by readers who share none of Marcus's cosmology. He has already done the work of showing that the practice does not depend on it — not as a concession to modern secularism, obviously, but because he could not settle the question himself and wanted an ethics that would hold regardless.

FLUX

The other half of the physics that Marcus actually uses is the doctrine of universal change, inherited from Heraclitus and worked hard. Everything is in the process of turning into something else. Your body is matter borrowed and shortly to be returned; the empire is a phase; the people you envy are already dissolving. He puts it in a dozen forms — that time is a river of passing events, that the present moment is a point between two eternities, that Vespasian's court and Trajan's court are gone and were exactly like this one, full of people marrying and quarrelling and suspecting each other and wishing others dead.

Two uses follow. The first is consolation: if everything is temporary then so is whatever is currently unbearable. The second is deflation, and it is the one he leans on harder: if everything is temporary then so is whatever you are chasing, and the reputation you are protecting will not outlast the people who hold it. There is a real bleakness in this and it would be dishonest to soften it — long stretches of the middle books are a man telling himself, repeatedly, that nothing matters very much. What keeps it from nihilism is the one thing he exempts: how you behave, right now, is not diminished by any of it.

"Soon you will have forgotten the world, and soon the world will have forgotten you."

BOOK 7.21

Most of the *Meditations* are scattered notes, but at 11.18 Marcus does something he almost never does: he writes out a numbered list. It is a protocol for dealing with anger at other people, and it is worth having in full, because it is the closest thing in the book to a set of instructions you could actually follow on a bad afternoon.

PLATE 10 THE TEN REMEDIES

1	WE WERE MADE FOR EACH OTHER	– TO WORK TOGETHER, LIKE FEET, HANDS AND EYELIDS
2	CONSIDER WHAT THEY ARE ACTUALLY LIKE	– AT TABLE, IN BED, AND ABOVE ALL WHAT THEIR OPINIONS COMPEL THEM TO DO
3	IF THEY ARE RIGHT, DON'T BE ANGRY	– AND IF WRONG, THEY ACT IN IGNORANCE AND AGAINST THEIR WILL
4	YOU DO PLENTY OF IT YOURSELF	– AND IF YOU ABSTAIN FROM A FAULT, IT IS FROM FEAR OR REPUTATION, NOT VIRTUE
5	YOU CANNOT BE SURE THEY DID WRONG	– MUCH IS DONE FROM POLICY; YOU NEED TO KNOW A GREAT DEAL BEFORE JUDGING
6	REMEMBER YOU ARE BOTH ABOUT TO DIE	– AND SHORTLY NO ONE WILL REMEMBER EITHER OF YOU
7	IT IS YOUR OPINION THAT STINGS, NOT THE ACT	– REMOVE THE JUDGEMENT AND THE INJURY GOES WITH IT
8	THE ANGER COSTS MORE THAN THE INJURY	– VEXATION AND GRIEF DAMAGE YOU MORE THAN THE THING THAT CAUSED THEM
9	KINDNESS IS UNANSWERABLE	– IF IT IS SINCERE, AND NOT SARCASM OR A DISPLAY
10	EXPECTING OTHERWISE IS MADNESS	– TO PERMIT IT IN GENERAL BUT FORBID IT TOWARD YOU IS TYRANNICAL

Item 7 is the general principle and everything else is an application of it. Item 4 is the one that does the most work in practice and the one most easily skipped: before deciding that someone has behaved badly, note how recently you did the same. Marcus adds a coda that the gift of the gods is that we should live with one another, and that anyone who withdraws from that is cutting himself off from his own nature.

Two features of the list are worth pausing on. The first is that only one of the ten — item 9 — is about what to do; the other nine are about how to see. This is consistent with the whole method: the intervention point is the judgement, not the behaviour, and if you get the judgement right the behaviour looks after itself. The second is that several of the items are arguments Marcus does not quite believe and knows he does not quite believe. Item 3, that wrongdoers act involuntarily, is a Socratic doctrine that most people find implausible on first hearing and that Marcus asserts rather than defends. He is not proving anything here. He is assembling a set of thoughts that, held together at the right moment, will make anger harder to sustain.

What He Actually Does

A small number of moves, run again and again.

Pierre Hadot's reading — that these are *spiritual exercises* rather than doctrines — has become the standard one, and it makes the repetition legible. Marcus is not developing a position. He is rehearsing a handful of manoeuvres so that they will be available when he needs them, in the way a soldier drills.

PLATE 11 THE THREE DISCIPLINES

DISCIPLINE	THE QUESTION	GOVERNS	FAILS AS
ASSENT PERCEPTION	IS THIS TRUE, OR IS IT A STORY I AM ADDING?	JUDGEMENTS ABOUT WHAT HAPPENED	SELF-DECEPTION; TAKING OFFENCE; RUMINATION
DESIRE ACCEPTANCE	IS THIS UP TO ME, OR IS IT UP TO NATURE?	WHAT I WANT AND WHAT I DREAD	CRAVING, FEAR OF DEATH, RESENTMENT AT FATE
ACTION JUSTICE	WHAT DOES THE COMMON GOOD REQUIRE OF ME NOW?	HOW I TREAT OTHER PEOPLE	LAZINESS, CRUELTY, USING PEOPLE AS MEANS

WHY THREE AND NOT ONE
THEY MAP ONTO LOGIC, PHYSICS AND ETHICS – THE WHOLE SYSTEM COMPRESSED INTO THREE QUESTIONS A BUSY MAN CAN ASK HIMSELF IN A MOMENT.

Almost every entry in Books 2–12 belongs to one of these three rows. Reading with the grid in hand converts the book from a pile of aphorisms into something with a visible structure, even though Marcus never names the structure himself.

PLATE 12 TWO MOVES HE USES CONSTANTLY

1 · OBJECTIVE DESCRIPTION

STRIP THE STORY OFF THE THING AND STATE WHAT IT IS

- A PURPLE ROBE → SHEEP'S WOOL, DYED WITH SHELLFISH BLOOD
- VINTAGE WINE → FERMENTED GRAPE JUICE
- ROAST MEAT → A DEAD ANIMAL
- FAME → NOISE MADE BY PEOPLE WHO WILL ALSO DIE

THE PURPOSE IS NOT CONTEMPT. IT IS TO SEE THE THING WITHOUT THE VALUE SOCIETY HAS PAINTED ONTO IT, SO THE CHOICE ABOUT IT CAN BE MADE FREELY.

OVERUSED, THIS BECOMES JOYLESS – A CRITICISM WORTH TAKING SERIOUSLY, AND ONE MARCUS HALF-ANTICIPATES WHEN HE WRITES ABOUT GRATITUDE.

2 · THE VIEW FROM ABOVE

CLIMB UNTIL THE SCALE IS HONEST
ALL OF TIME



"ALEXANDER THE GREAT AND HIS MULE-DRIVER BOTH DIED, AND THE SAME THING HAPPENED TO BOTH OF THEM."

Both exercises do the same work from opposite directions: one shrinks the object, the other enlarges the frame. Marcus applies them ruthlessly to his own position – the whole apparatus of imperial ceremony is, on this view, sheep's wool and noise.

Because the books have no titles, no themes and no order, the standard experience of the *Meditations* is remembering a line and being unable to find it. What follows is a map: what each book contains, and the reference for the entries most people are looking for. Citations are given as book.section, which works in any edition and any translation.

PLATE 13 THE TWELVE BOOKS, AND THEIR LANDMARKS

BK	CHARACTER	LANDMARK ENTRIES
1	DEBTS AND LESSONS	SEVENTEEN PEOPLE; 1.16 ON ANTONINUS; 1.17 TO THE GODS
2	WRITTEN AMONG THE QUADI	2.1 THE MORNING REMINDER · 2.14 YOU CAN ONLY LOSE THE PRESENT
3	WRITTEN AT CARNUNTUM	3.4 DON'T WASTE WHAT'S LEFT OF YOUR LIFE ON OTHER PEOPLE'S THOUGHTS
4	THE DENSEST BOOK	4.3 THE RETREAT INTO YOURSELF; PROVIDENCE OR ATOMS · 4.7 REMOVE THE JUDGEMENT
5	DUTY AND RELUCTANCE	5.1 GETTING OUT OF BED · 5.20 THE IMPEDIMENT BECOMES THE WAY
6	THE MOST QUOTABLE	6.6 THE BEST REVENGE · 6.13 THE PURPLE ROBE · 6.44 MY CITY IS THE WORLD · 6.54 THE HIVE
7	PAIN, AND OTHER MINDS	7.21 SOON FORGOTTEN · 7.59 LOOK WITHIN – THE FOUNTAIN OF GOOD IS THERE
8	DOING THE WORK IN FRONT OF YOU	8.47 IF YOU ARE DISTRESSED BY ANYTHING EXTERNAL, REVOKE THE ESTIMATE
9	WRONGDOING AS IMPIETY	9.28 THE UNIVERSE TURNING OVER · 9.42 ON EXPECTING PEOPLE TO BE OTHERWISE
10	IMPATIENCE WITH HIMSELF	10.16 WASTE NO MORE TIME ARGUING WHAT A GOOD MAN IS – BE ONE
11	ANGER, AND THE CHRISTIANS	11.18 THE TEN REMEDIES FOR ANGER · 11.3 THE DISPUTED LINE ON CHRISTIANS
12	VALEDICTORY	12.36 YOU HAVE LIVED AS A CITIZEN IN A GREAT CITY; LEAVE IT GRACIOUSLY

SECTION NUMBERING IS STABLE ACROSS EDITIONS; THE WORDING IS NOT. ANY TWO TRANSLATIONS OF 5.20 WILL DIFFER CONSIDERABLY.

If you want a single book to try before committing, take Book 6. It has the highest density of the entries everyone quotes and it is representative of the middle stretch. Book 4 is the one philosophers rate highest and the one that repays rereading.

MARCUS AMONG THE STOICS

The three Roman Stoics whose work survives are startlingly different as writers, and knowing which is which saves a lot of confusion. **Seneca** is a courtier and a stylist: his letters are polished, epigrammatic, written for publication, and shadowed by the awkward fact that he was Nero's tutor and one of the richest men in Rome while writing about the unimportance of wealth. **Epictetus** is a teacher and was born a slave: the *Discourses* are lecture notes taken by a student, and the tone is direct, sometimes abrasive, addressed to a room. Marcus is neither — he is writing to one person, himself, with no audience to persuade and no reputation at stake, and that is why the book reads as it does.

PLATE 14 THREE ROMAN STOICS, AND ONE GREEK SCHOOL APIECE

SENECA		EPICTETUS		MARCUS
C. 4 BCE – 65 CE		C. 55 – 135 CE		121 – 180 CE
STATION	SENATOR, PLAYWRIGHT, NERO'S TUTOR; VERY RICH		BORN A SLAVE; FREED; RAN A SCHOOL IN GREECE	EMPEROR OF ROME FROM 161
FORM	POLISHED LETTERS AND ESSAYS		LECTURE NOTES TAKEN DOWN BY A STUDENT	PRIVATE NOTES, IN GREEK, UNEDITED
WRITING FOR	POSTERITY, AND A FRIEND		A ROOM FULL OF STUDENTS	HIMSELF, AND NO ONE ELSE
TONE	ELEGANT, QUOTABLE, OCCASIONALLY SELF-SERVING		BLUNT, HECTORING, IMMEDIATELY PRACTICAL	WEARY, REPETITIVE, UNGUARDED
START WITH EPICTETUS'S HANDBOOK IF YOU WANT THE DOCTRINE STATED PLAINLY; START WITH MARCUS IF YOU WANT TO WATCH SOMEONE TRYING TO LIVE IT.				

The absence of an audience is the whole difference. Seneca is always aware of being read and Epictetus is always aware of being heard; Marcus has nobody to impress, which is why he is willing to record that he could not get out of bed.

AND AMONG THE SCHOOLS

It is also worth knowing what Stoicism was competing against, because Marcus's positions are often responses to live alternatives rather than statements of the obvious. The Hellenistic schools were all answering one question — how should a person live, given that the world is not arranged for your benefit? — and they gave genuinely different answers.

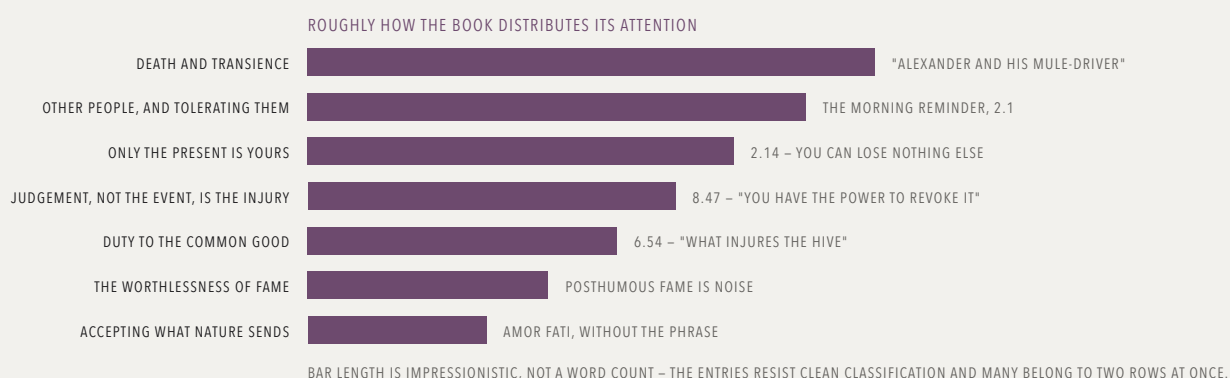
PLATE 15 FOUR ANSWERS TO THE SAME QUESTION

SCHOOL	THE GOOD IS	PUBLIC LIFE	THE ROUTE TO CALM
STOIC ZENO, MARCUS	VIRTUE, AND NOTHING ELSE	A DUTY – ENGAGE	ACCEPT WHAT IS NOT YOURS TO CONTROL
EPICUREAN EPICURUS, LUCRETIUS	PLEASURE, MEANING ABSENCE OF PAIN	AVOID IT – "LIVE UNNOTICED"	SIMPLE WANTS; FRIENDS; NO FEAR OF GODS
CYNIC DIOGENES	VIRTUE THROUGH SHAMELESSNESS	MOCK IT FROM OUTSIDE	OWN NOTHING; NEED NOTHING
SCEPTIC PYRRHO, SEXTUS	NOTHING CAN BE KNOWN SECURELY	CONFORM WITHOUT BELIEVING	SUSPEND JUDGEMENT ON EVERYTHING
MARCUS KNOWS ALL OF THESE AND BORROWS FROM ALL OF THEM. HIS "PROVIDENCE OR ATOMS" CONCEDES THE EPICUREAN PHYSICS AS A LIVE OPTION; THE OBJECTIVE-DESCRIPTION EXERCISE IS CYNIC IN SPIRIT; AND HIS CAUTION ABOUT CERTAINTY IS CLOSER TO THE SCEPTICS THAN ORTHODOXY ALLOWED.			

The row that matters for reading Marcus is the third column. Stoicism is the school that requires you to participate – to hold office, raise children, fight the war, sit in the Senate. This is why it was the philosophy of the Roman governing class, and why its modern reduction to a private calm technique loses so much.

The *Meditations* have no plot and no development, but they do have obsessions, and the obsessions are countable. A handful of themes account for most of the book, and Marcus circles them with a persistence that is either monotonous or moving depending on how you read it. My own view is that the repetition is the most informative thing about the text: **a man does not write the same reminder to himself for ten years unless he keeps needing it.**

PLATE 16 THE RECURRING SUBJECTS, BY WEIGHT



The top two rows are the giveaway. Marcus is not primarily writing about metaphysics or virtue in the abstract; he is writing about dying, and about how hard he finds other people. Those are the problems of a specific man in a specific job, not the syllabus of a school.

DEATH, CONSTANTLY

No other theme comes close. Marcus reminds himself that he will die, that everyone he knows will die, that everyone who might remember him will die, and that the people who might remember *those* people will die too. He lists emperors and their courts — Augustus, his wife, his daughter, his descendants, his advisers, "all dead, all buried" — and notes that they had seemed permanent at the time. He observes that Alexander the Great and his mule-driver came to the same end. He tells himself not to behave "as though you were going to live ten thousand years."

The purpose of this is not morbidity, and reading it as gloom misses the mechanism. Marcus is using mortality as a scaling device. Almost everything that provokes anxiety — a slight from a courtier, a delayed dispatch, a question of precedence — becomes negligible when set against a span in which the whole Roman world is a brief episode. He is trying to be permanently unimpressed by his own circumstances, and death is the most reliable instrument he has for that. There is also a second, quieter use: if this is the only life, then the present hour is the whole of the available stock, and wasting it on resentment is expensive in a way that can actually be felt.

OTHER PEOPLE

The second theme is the one modern readers find most immediately usable, because it is so unmistakably the complaint of someone who spends his days in meetings. The famous entry that opens Book 2 tells him what to expect on waking: the people he deals with today will be meddling, ungrateful, arrogant, dishonest and surly. What follows, though, is the part usually left out of the quotation. They are like this, he says, because they cannot tell good from bad — and since he has understood that goodness is beautiful and badness ugly, and since they are his kin, not by blood but by sharing in the same reason, he cannot be injured by them and he cannot hate them.

This is a much stranger and more demanding thought than the tolerance it is usually reduced to. It is not "people are difficult, so be patient." It is a claim that wrongdoing is a species of ignorance — the old Socratic position — and that therefore anger at a wrongdoer is as misplaced as anger at someone who has made an arithmetical error. Whether that is true is genuinely arguable; Marcus does not argue it, he assumes it. What he does instead is rehearse the consequence over and over, in dozens of variations, because the doctrine is easy to hold in the abstract and nearly impossible to hold at the moment somebody is being intolerable to you.

"It can ruin your life only if it ruins your character. Otherwise it cannot harm you — inside or out."

BOOK 4.8

THE PRESENT, AND THE OBSTACLE

Two shorter but heavily worked seams. On the present: Marcus observes that whatever length of life a person has, they can only ever lose the present moment, since the past is already gone and the future is not theirs to lose. From this he draws the odd but consoling conclusion that the longest and shortest lives come to the same thing at the point of loss. On obstacles: the line at 5.20 — the impediment to action advances action, what stands in the way becomes the way — has been flattened by modern quotation into a slogan about grit, which is not quite what it says. His point is narrower and better: an obstruction to one purpose is raw material for another, because the virtue you are actually practising is not "getting this done" but "responding well to what is in front of me," and an obstacle supplies as much occasion for that as a clear road does.

AND THE RELUCTANCE TO GET UP IN THE MORNING

The single most humanising entry in the book is at 5.1, and it deserves quoting at something like length because it is where the distance between an emperor and a reader collapses entirely. At dawn, when he does not want to get out of bed, he is to tell himself: I am rising to do the work of a human being. Why should I complain, if I am going out to do what I was born for and what I was brought into the world to do? Or was I made for this — to lie under the blankets and keep myself warm? And then, a few lines later, the note of exasperation with himself: *but this is more pleasant*. Do you exist, then, for pleasure — and not at all for action and exertion?

He is the ruler of the Roman empire, at war, in his fifties, and he is arguing with himself about the snooze button. The entry is undated but it is not a one-off: variations on it appear in at least four books. Whatever else the *Meditations* are, they are evidence that the internal experience of being a person has changed remarkably little in eighteen hundred years, and that neither power nor philosophy makes the morning easier.

The *Meditations* are usually read as a self-contained moral document, and read that way they are close to unimpeachable. Set beside the life of the man who wrote them, they raise questions the text itself never touches — and a reader who takes the book seriously should know where those questions are rather than discover them later and feel misled.

The largest is the one that hangs over all ancient ethics. Marcus writes movingly that his city, so far as he is a man, is the world; that all rational beings share one citizenship; that what does not harm the community does not harm its members. He ruled a society in which perhaps a fifth of the population were legally property, and there is nothing in the twelve books suggesting he considered this a problem. Epictetus, his own principal source, had been a slave. The Stoic doctrine of universal brotherhood was, for Marcus, entirely compatible with the institution — as it was for almost everyone in antiquity. This is not a reason to dismiss the book, but it is a real limit on how far its universalism actually reached, and it should temper the common claim that Stoicism was ahead of its time on human equality.

Second: Christians were executed during his reign, most notoriously at Lyons in 177, and the single reference to them in the *Meditations* (11.3) is dismissive — he praises the soul that is ready to leave the body through its own judgement rather than "in sheer opposition, like the Christians." Whether Marcus ordered or approved those executions is genuinely disputed by historians; the machinery of provincial governors did not need imperial instruction. Some scholars also think the phrase is a later interpolation. Either way, the man writing about tolerance and kinship was presiding over a state that killed people for a religious refusal.

Third, and most damaging to the romantic reading: he chose his son Commodus as successor. It was the first biological succession in eighty-four years, breaking a run of adoptions that had produced four capable emperors, and Commodus was a catastrophe — vain, murderous, and eventually strangled in his bath. The *Meditations*, written across exactly the years in which that decision was being made and confirmed, contain no reflection on it at all. There is likewise nothing about the plague that devastated his empire, nothing about the deaths of most of his children, and nothing about the revolt of Avidius Cassius. The notebook is not a record of his life. It is a record of one activity within it, and it is silent about almost everything a biographer would want.

THE HONEST SUMMARY

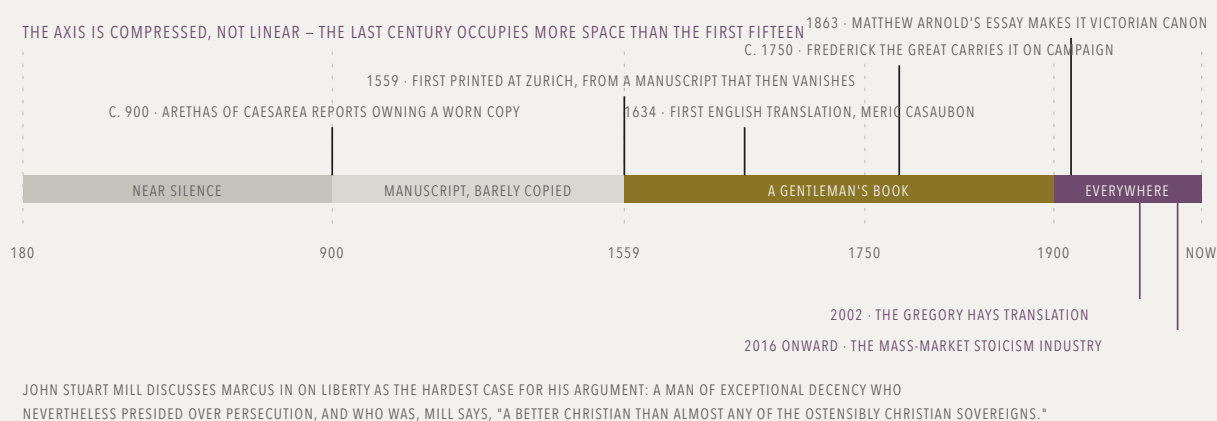
This is an excellent book about how to manage your own mind, written by a man who was probably a better-than-average ruler and certainly not a moral revolutionary. It tells you nothing about whether he was right to hold power, and it was never trying to. Treating it as a testimonial for its author — rather than as a set of exercises that can be assessed on their own merits — is the commonest mistake made about it.

From Nothing to Everywhere

Eighteen centuries in which the book was mostly ignored, and two decades in which it was not.

One of the odder facts about the *Meditations* is how recent its fame is. For most of its existence it was a curiosity known to a few scholars. It has been a mass-market book for roughly twenty years. **The version of Marcus that circulates today — quotable, motivational, compatible with a morning routine — is a very late arrival, and it is worth knowing which parts of it come from the text and which from the packaging.**

PLATE 17 THE RECEPTION, 180 TO THE PRESENT



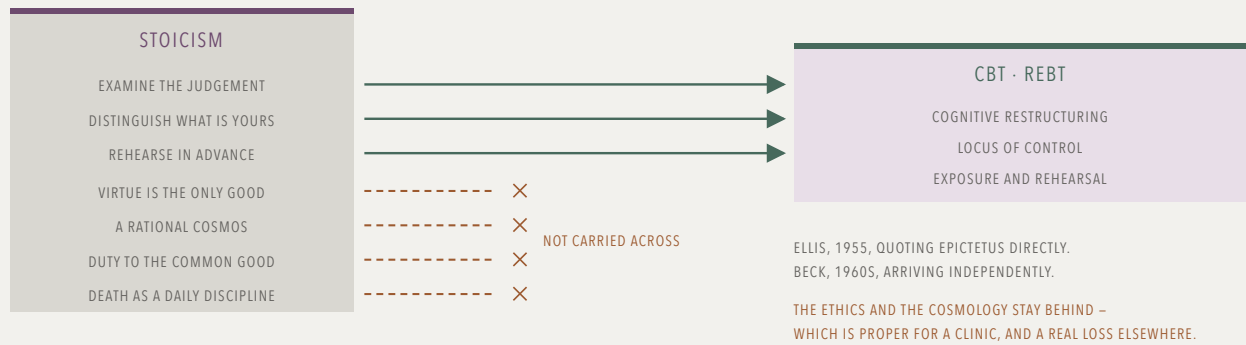
The Arnold essay is the hinge for the English-speaking world; the Hays translation is the hinge for the present moment. Both did the same thing – made an awkward text sound like something a contemporary reader would want to read – and both are therefore worth being slightly suspicious of.

THE LINE INTO MODERN PSYCHOTHERAPY

The most substantive afterlife of Stoicism is not literary but clinical. When Albert Ellis developed Rational Emotive Behavior Therapy in the 1950s, he credited Epictetus directly and quoted him constantly: *men are disturbed not by things, but by the views which they take of them*. Aaron Beck's cognitive therapy, developed independently in the 1960s, arrived at a structurally identical move. The core technique of both — identify the automatic thought, examine the belief that produced it, test whether it survives inspection — is the discipline of assent, rediscovered.

What carried across is the cognitive machinery. What did not is everything that gave the machinery a point. Marcus does not examine his judgements in order to feel better; he examines them because he thinks some of them are *false*, and because a person whose judgements are false is not living well regardless of how he feels. The Stoic claim is that virtue is the only good, which is a claim about value, not about mood. Strip that out and you are left with a technique for managing distress — genuinely useful, demonstrably effective, and not what the book is about.

PLATE 18 WHAT CROSSED OVER, AND WHAT WAS LEFT BEHIND



A therapy has no business prescribing what its patients should value, so the omission is entirely correct in context. The problem arises when the clinical version travels back out into general culture as though it were the whole of Stoicism – at which point "what is up to me" becomes a productivity concept rather than a moral one.

More than with almost any other classic, the translation decides whether this book works for you. Marcus's Greek is compressed, unliterary and often ungrammatical — he was writing notes, not prose — and translators have to decide whether to smooth it or preserve it. The difference between versions is not stylistic garnish; it changes what the book seems to be.

Gregory Hays (Modern Library, 2002) is the version most people should start with. It is punchy, contemporary and unafraid of short sentences, and it makes Marcus sound like someone thinking rather than someone declaiming. Purists object that it takes liberties; it does, and it is still the one that gets read to the end. **Robin Hard** (Oxford World's Classics) and **Martin Hammond** (Penguin) are both more literal, both excellent, and both come with substantially better notes — Hard's introduction by Christopher Gill is the best short account of the philosophy attached to any popular edition. Avoid the free **George Long** translation of 1862 that circulates everywhere online: it is out of copyright, which is why it is everywhere, and its Victorian diction makes an unfussy book sound pompous.

As for method: do not read it straight through. The book has no argument to follow and reading it cover to cover in two sittings produces fatigue and a false sense of monotony. It was written in fragments over years and it works best consumed the same way — a few entries at a time, ideally when you actually need them. Many readers keep it as a bedside or morning book for years and report that different entries surface as relevant at different points of life, which is what you would expect of a text organised around problems rather than around topics.

PLATE 19 FOUR THINGS STOICISM IS ROUTINELY TAKEN TO MEAN, AND DOES NOT

THE POPULAR VERSION

SUPPRESS YOUR EMOTIONS; FEEL NOTHING

ACCEPT EVERYTHING; DO NOT RESIST

A PRIVATE OPTIMISATION FOR THE INDIVIDUAL

A TECHNIQUE FOR GETTING MORE DONE

WHAT THE TEXT SAYS

EXAMINE THE JUDGEMENT THAT PRODUCES THE EMOTION.
MARCUS GRIEVES, IS IRRITATED, AND SAYS SO REPEATEDLY.

ACT WITH EVERYTHING YOU HAVE; THEN ACCEPT THE OUTCOME,
WHICH WAS NEVER YOURS. HE FOUGHT A TEN-YEAR WAR.

HALF THE DOCTRINE IS JUSTICE AND THE COMMON GOOD.
"WHAT INJURES THE HIVE INJURES THE BEE."

THE AIM IS TO BE GOOD, NOT EFFECTIVE. PRODUCTIVITY IS
NOT A STOIC CATEGORY AND DOES NOT APPEAR IN THE BOOK.

The fourth row is the one worth guarding against, because it is the form the book most often takes in modern circulation. Marcus is not offering a method for achieving your goals; he is offering a method for holding your goals loosely enough that failing at them does not deform you.

Between
what
happens
and
how
you feel
about it
there is
a step –
the
assent –
and that
step is
the only
place in
the
whole
chain
where
you
have
any
purchase.
Almost
every
exercise
in the
book is
aimed
at
widening
it.

Your
judgement,
your
intention,
your
conduct.
Not
your
body,
your
reputation,
other
people,
or
whether
the plan
works.
The
discipline
is in
applying
it to the
specific
thing
bothering
you
today,
not in
agreeing
with it
in
general.

03 **Obligation survives the loss of control.**

That
outcomes
are not
up to
you
does
not
release
you
from
acting
well.
This is
the
hinge
that
separates
Stoicism
from
fatalism,
and the
one
modern
summaries
most
often
drop.

04 **Other people are difficult because they are mistaken, not because they are enemies.**

Marcus
asks
himself
to treat
wrongdoing
as a
failure
of
understanding.
Whether
or not
that is
true,
holding
it
makes
anger
structurally
harder
to
sustain.

05 **Scale is a tool.**

Death,
deep
time,
the view
from
above,
the
plain
physical
description
of a
prized
object –
four
ways of
getting
the size
of a
thing
right
when
your
position
or your
fear has
distorted
it.

06 **Only the present can be lost.**

The past
is spent
and the
future is
not yet
yours,
so
nothing
else is
actually
at stake.
This is
the
entry
that
does
the
most
work at
three in
the
morning.

Book 12
is
telling
him
what
Book 2
told
him.
There is
no
arrival,
no
graduation,
no state
of
being
fixed.
The
practice
is the
thing,
and the
evidence
that a
man
could
run it
for a
decade
and still
need it
is the
most
reassuring
fact in
the
book.

COLOPHON

Meditations • Marcus Aurelius

A reader's summary of the twelve books of *Tà eis heautón*, written c. 170–180 CE and first printed in 1559. Quotations are given by book and section so they can be found in any edition; wording follows no single translation, since the point is usually the thought rather than the phrasing. Every plate was drawn for this document.

THE BOOK IN ONE LINE

The private notebook of a man trying,
daily, to be reasonable.

PLATES

10 hand-drawn figures
Prose-led; diagrams where they earn
their place

BEST FIRST TRANSLATION

Gregory Hays · Modern Library, 2002
then Hard (Oxford) or Hammond
(Penguin)

READ ALONGSIDE

Epictetus · Discourses and Handbook
Pierre Hadot · The Inner Citadel